

Valley News Dispatch

'Nexus of trails' envisioned for region

By Brian C. Rittmeyer

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Hugging riverbanks, meandering with creeks and running through valleys, trails throughout the region offer places to bike, walk and enjoy the outdoors for fun and fitness.

Some are complete, some have gaps yet to be filled in and others exist only as dreams on drawing boards.

They can be used for a quick outing from home or be traveled miles to far-flung destinations.

Volunteers and organizations are working to maintain them, grow them and build them.

ARMSTRONG TRAIL

Armstrong Rails to Trails volunteers have had to combat the wet spring and early summer heat to build and maintain 18 miles of finished trail.

Trail-building efforts are focused this year between Grays Eddy and Hook Station.

Donations have been used to buy crushed limestone, which is spread over newly graded sections of trail. A grant will pay for buying more to build another mile of trail this summer in that area.

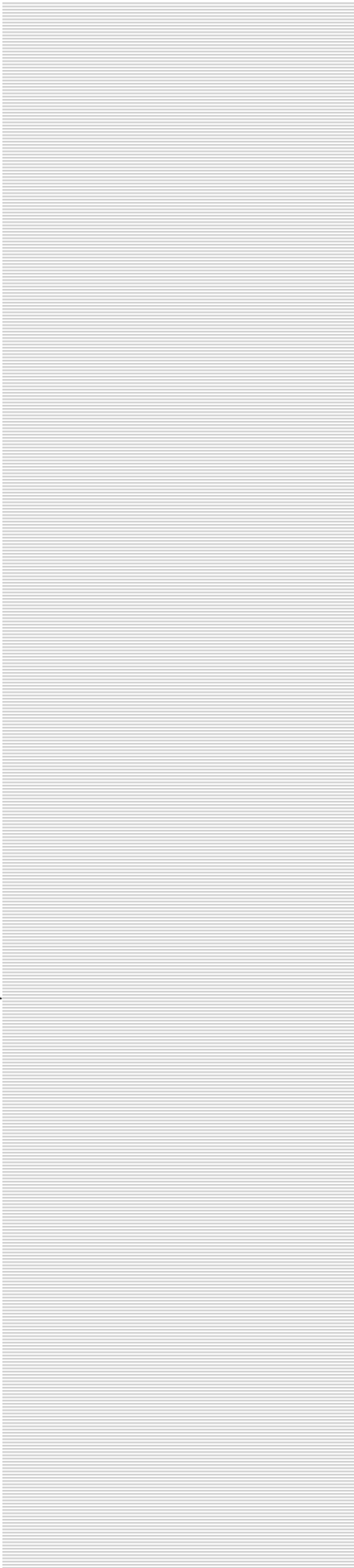
The Allegheny Valley Land Trust, which owns the trail corridor, has applied for a state grant to get money to buy materials to build a five-mile section between Lock and Dam 9 near Rimer and Phillipston.

Another grant is being sought to pay for a study of a campground in the Phillipston area and to evaluate the Brady tunnel for renovation as a future connection to the Allegheny River Trail.

These projects will reduce the unfinished section of the trail to about six miles. The group has set spring 2014 as the goal for having the trail's 30 continuous miles from Rosston south of Kittanning to East Brady finished, said Toni Henry, of East Brady, vice president of the Armstrong Rails to Trails Association.

"Our goal is to fill in the gaps," she said.

The trail effort began 15 years ago and, like many such efforts, hit resistance in lawsuits and disputes over ownership and concerns from those whose homes and properties were near the proposed trails. As those have been resolved, work on the trail has accelerated in the past two years and Henry said much progress has been made.



There might still be cases of where a neighbor cuts down a tree and blocks the trail, or someone vandalizes it with a prohibited all-terrain vehicle. But the trees get removed; the ruts filled.

"Our philosophy is we keep moving forward," she said.

An avid bicyclist, Henry said the trail is not only a benefit for personal physical health, but also for the economic well-being of the small towns along it that can benefit from trail users buying lunch, getting their bikes fixed and spending the night in a bed and breakfast.

"The longer the trail, the greater the economic benefit," she said.

TREDWAY TRAIL

In Allegheny Township, efforts continue to build and expand the Tredway Trail along the Allegheny River.

The trail exists in thirds -- about a third is finished and in use, another third has been bought and needs developed, and the township is working on buying the final third, said township Supervisor Kathy Starr.

In March, the township wrapped up buying a 1.5-mile section of the former railbed in the River Forest area. The path connects the trail to the Freeport Bridge. A \$150,000 state grant was used toward the purchase.

Rather than spending money to improve the newly purchased portion, Starr said the township will focus any money it gets toward buying the remaining stretch from the Freeport Bridge up to the Kiski River. The township has applied for another grant.

"After we own it all, then we'll worry about improving it and making it user friendly," Starr said. "Our public works folks can do it."

Once complete to Freeport and the Kiski River, the Tredway Trail could link with others that converge there, such as the Butler Freeport Community Trail, Starr said.

Starr called the trail "a wonderful asset for our community," which contributes to making the area more attractive as a desirable place to live and work.

"Getting these trails developed and getting people a venue where they can exercise, walk, bike and be out in the fresh air was a good back-to-nature thing to do," she said. "We have the opportunity to complete a section of the trail that eventually will go all the way to Washington, D.C. Anything we can do to put our two cents into the link is what we want to do."

PITTSBURGH TO FREEPORT

A major effort that remains underway is the extension of the Three Rivers Heritage Trail over 16 miles through 18 municipalities between Pittsburgh and Freeport.

The trail as it exists today extends upriver from the North Shore to Millvale.

Descriptions of the trail had been sent to each of the local governments, who have a week left to give their final comments, said Tom Baxter, executive director of the Friends of the Riverfront.

The comments will be reviewed and provided to a consultant, who will submit a draft report to the state for review.

A public meeting will then be held, where the project's phases -- what's happening now, what's on the horizon and what's long-term -- will be discussed, Baxter said. The meeting has not yet been scheduled.

Work on the project is coming up on two years.

"This is a tremendous undertaking. We want to make sure we get it right," Baxter said.

How long the trail may take to finish will be revealed when the plan is presented at the public meetings, he said.

Obstacles include railroad lines, commercial sites along the river, crowded communities and congested roads.

"The Three Rivers Heritage Trail itself is part of the National Recreation Trail. This corridor really ranks high. It's also a major part of an Allegheny County plan called Active Allegheny," Baxter said. "I can't imagine any project rating any higher."

Baxter envisions Pittsburgh becoming a "nexus of trails," from where bicyclists could travel to destinations including Erie and the nation's capital.

"The potential's here and there's a lot of good people working hard to make sure that happens," he said.

Despite deficits and money concerns at all levels of government, Baxter isn't worried about funding.

"This is a long-term project. Budgets will change, funding sources will come and go," he said. "We'll work with our funding partners and when the opportunity comes, we'll take advantage of it."

Baxter said he has seen public interest and excitement in the trails surge over the years to where larger venues are needed for meetings concerning them.

"We've not had any opposition, just questions, a dialogue, which is great," he said. "We've turned a corner. People understand that trails and green space are good for the economy, health and vitality of our communities."

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